Your First Showing Field Guide

A room-by-room checklist and what to ask before you leave

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Start here

Most first showings go the same way: you walk in, the staging looks great, twenty minutes fly by, and back in the car you realize you never looked at the basement.

This guide fixes that. It gives you a route through the house, what to look at in each room, the questions to ask before you leave, and a short debrief for the car. Use it at any showing or open house where you need to decide one thing: does this home deserve a second look?

Read it once now, then bring the Room-by-Room Checklist, the Car Debrief, and the Questions to ask before you leave pages with you.

- **You won't spot everything.** That's what the home inspection is for. This guide is not a substitute for a professional home inspection by a licensed Massachusetts home inspector.
- **Your first showing is practice, not a final exam.** The typical buyer searches about 10 weeks (NAR 2025 Profile of Home Buyers and Sellers).
- **Touring with an agent?** Expect to sign a written buyer agreement before your first tour, in person or by live video. Visiting an open house on your own doesn't require one (NAR).

Step 1: What to bring

- Phone, charged (photos, notes, flashlight)
- This guide, printed or open on your phone
- Your ranked must-haves list
- A tape measure or measuring app, for the furniture you're keeping
- Shoes that slip on and off easily
- Your budget in your head, not on paper you might leave behind

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Step 2: Walk the house in this order

Opening closets and cabinets is normal at a showing. Going through the seller's personal belongings is not.

Follow the listing's showing instructions. Ask before running water or touching thermostats or other systems.

The route takes about 20 minutes:

1. **Outside, before you go in.** 2 minutes.
2. **Kitchen.** 3 minutes.
3. **Bathrooms.** 3 minutes.
4. **Bedrooms and living spaces.** 4 minutes.
5. **Basement.** 5 minutes. Don't skip it.
6. **Outside again.** 3 minutes.

What to check at each stop is on the Room-by-Room Checklist later in this guide.

Step 3: Cosmetic vs. worth a closer look

Usually cosmetic (don't let these scare you off)

- Paint colors
- Dated light fixtures and hardware
- Carpet
- Wallpaper
- Staging you don't love

Worth asking your inspector about

- Water stains on ceilings or in the basement
- Musty smells
- Cracks in foundation walls
- An older electrical panel or very few outlets
- Roof wear
- Windows that won't open or are rotted
- An old heating system

Jared's take

First-time buyers often walk away from homes with ugly paint and fall for homes with a fresh coat over real problems. Ignore the colors and follow the water. Stains, smells, and slopes tell you more than any staging.

Step 4: Older Newton homes

48.8% of Newton's housing units were built in 1939 or earlier (U.S. Census Bureau, ACS 2020-2024 5-year). If the home you're seeing is older, also notice:

- Radiators or older heating equipment
- Two-prong (ungrounded) outlets
- Windows painted shut
- A fill pipe or vent on the outside wall, which can mean an oil tank, current or old

Built before 1978? Lead paint

- Massachusetts requires the seller and any agent to give you the state's Property Transfer Lead Paint Notification before you sign a purchase and sale agreement.
- Ask for it before you sign your offer, too, since an accepted offer can be binding.
- You get at least 10 days (longer if you and the seller agree) to have a lead inspection or risk assessment done, if you choose to. You can also waive it in writing.
- At a foreclosure sale, the federal lead disclosure rule doesn't apply (40 CFR 745.101), but Massachusetts still requires the state notice, with no 10-day window: you sign that you won't get a chance to inspect for lead before the sale (105 CMR 460.720).

For the full process, ask for my First-Time Buyer Roadmap.

Step 5: The car debrief

Wait until you're in the car. Then answer the Car Debrief questions in under 5 minutes, while it's fresh. The page is later in this guide.

Jared's take

Don't trust your memory after three showings in one afternoon. They blur together fast. Five minutes of debrief notes in the car is worth more than an hour of trying to remember which one had the good basement.

Get the Room-by-Room Checklist and the Car Debrief on the next pages!

Room-by-Room Checklist (copy one per home)

About 20 minutes, in this order. Ask before running water or touching thermostats or other systems.

- Home: _____
- Date and time visited: _____

1. Outside, before you go in (2 minutes)

- Roof: missing, curling, or patched shingles
- Gutters and downspouts: attached, draining away from the house
- Ground slope: does it run away from the foundation or toward it?
- Siding, trim, and window frames: peeling paint, soft or rotted wood
- Driveway and walkways: big cracks or heaving

2. Kitchen (3 minutes)

- Under the sink: water stains, warped cabinet floor, musty smell
- Faucet, with your agent's OK: pressure and how long hot water takes
- Appliances: look for age labels inside doors
- Cabinets and counters: open a few, check hinges and drawers
- Outlets near the counters: enough of them, in workable spots

3. Bathrooms (3 minutes)

- Shower and sink, with your agent's OK: pressure and drainage. Skip it if the home is vacant or winterized, and leave everything dry.
- Floor around the toilet: any soft spots or movement
- Caulk and grout around the tub or shower
- Ventilation fan: is there one, and does it work?
- Ceiling: stains or peeling paint from moisture

4. Bedrooms and living spaces (4 minutes)

- Ceilings, especially under bathrooms: stains or patches
- Windows: open one or two that move easily (don't force a stuck one); check for drafts and painted-shut sashes
- Floors: soft spots, slopes, squeaks
- Closet sizes compared to what you own
- Natural light at this time of day

5. Basement (5 minutes; don't skip it)

- Smell: musty or damp
- Walls and floor: water lines, stains, white chalky residue
- Heating system and water heater: age labels if visible
- Electrical panel: note what you can see from a distance
- Sump pump or dehumidifier running: ask why
- Ceiling height and how usable the space is

6. Outside again (3 minutes)

- Stand on the street for one minute: traffic and noise at this hour
- Parking: driveway, garage, or street, and how it would work for you
- Yard and outdoor space compared to your must-haves

Car Debrief (copy one per home)

Wait until you're in the car. Then answer these in under 5 minutes, while it's fresh.

- Home: _____

The questions

- Would I be happy coming home here on a rainy Tuesday?

_____
_____

- What's the first thing I'd change, and could I afford to change it?

_____
_____

- Did anything feel like a dealbreaker?

_____
_____

- How does it compare to the last home I saw?

_____
_____

The decision

- Score it on the showing scorecard in my Before You Tour kit.
- Second look: yes, maybe, or no _____

Questions to ask before you leave

In Massachusetts, sellers don't have to fill out a disclosure form, and a private seller generally doesn't have to volunteer the home's condition (lead paint is the main exception). A seller can't lie when you ask a direct question, so asking directly matters.

Agents are held to a higher standard, including disclosing known facts that could change your decision. At an open house, the host usually works for the seller. Ask about the home, and keep your budget and timeline to yourself.

The home

- How old are the roof, heating system, and water heater?
- Any known water in the basement, now or in the past?
- What do utilities typically run per month?
- Any recent renovations, and were they permitted?
- Built before 1978? Is there a lead inspection report, Letter of Compliance, or Letter of Interim Control?

The sale

- How are offers being handled? Is there an offer deadline?
- What's included: appliances, window treatments, anything else?

Condos

- What does the condo fee cover?
- Any planned special assessments or big building projects?

Your next step

Going to showings or open houses this weekend? Send me the list, and I'll tell you the one or two things I'd look at first in each home.

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Sources

- National Association of REALTORS®, 2025 Profile of Home Buyers and Sellers, released November 4, 2025 (nar.realtor): the typical buyer's home search of about 10 weeks.
- National Association of REALTORS®, Consumer Guide to Written Buyer Agreements (nar.realtor): a written buyer agreement before touring with an agent, in person or by live video, and none needed to visit an open house on your own.
- U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey 2020–2024 5-year estimates, table DP04 (Selected Housing Characteristics), Newton city, Massachusetts, released January 2026 (census.gov): 48.8% of Newton's housing units built in 1939 or earlier.
- Massachusetts Department of Public Health, Property Transfer Lead Paint Notification (mass.gov): the state notice for homes built before 1978.
- Massachusetts General Laws c.111 §197A, checked November 9, 2026 (malegislature.gov): the seller's and agent's duty to notify before a purchase and sale agreement.
- Code of Massachusetts Regulations, 105 CMR 460.720, Property Transfer Lead Notification and Disclosure, amended effective December 1, 2017, checked November 9, 2026 (law.cornell.edu): the state notice before a purchase and sale agreement, the 10-day inspection period in (B)(1), and the foreclosure-sale rule in (B)(2) (notice still required, with a signed acknowledgment of no inspection).
- U.S. EPA and HUD lead disclosure rule, 40 CFR 745.101 (exemptions, including (a) sales of target housing at foreclosure) and 745.110, checked November 9, 2026 (law.cornell.edu).
- Massachusetts Real Estate Law Blog, "Is 'Buyer Beware' Alive and Well? An Overview of Massachusetts Real Estate Disclosure Law," June 21, 2011 (massrealestatelawblog.com): no required seller disclosure form, a private seller's general duty, and the higher standard for agents.
- Code of Massachusetts Regulations, 940 CMR 3.16(2), Attorney General consumer protection regulations, checked November 9, 2026 (law.cornell.edu): failing to disclose to a buyer any fact that may have influenced the buyer not to enter the transaction is an unfair or deceptive act.
- Board of Registration of Real Estate Brokers and Salespersons, course page RE04RC12: M.G.L. c. 93A, Consumer Protection & Business Regulation, confirmed through search results on November 9, 2026 (mass.gov): c. 93A applies to real estate licensees.

Disclaimer

Jared Cohen, REALTOR® | eXp Realty. Licensed real estate salesperson in Massachusetts.
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